Client Consulting Assignment

Module Code: BBM 104 | Module Title: Effective Management Consulting

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BBM104 Effective Management Consultancy

Project Approval Form

Please complete this one page form to summarise your proposed problem for the focus of your study.

Section	
Your name and student number	
Name of the issue you will be studying	Balancing self-checkout automation with customer experience and loss prevention in UK retail.
Client(s) (please describe who will be the client for your study)	A major UK high-street supermarket chain (e.g. Tesco, Sainsbury's or Asda), represented by store operations and customer experience management, who would receive the conclusions and recommendations of this study.
Sector (please describe which sector this organisation is in i.e. automotive, healthcare, financial services etc)	Retail (grocery/supermarket sector), with a focus on in-store technology adoption and customer service operations.
What will be the geography and demographic of the problem	Nationwide UK, with particular relevance to high-footfall urban and suburban store locations. All customer demographics, with particular impact on older customers, customers with disabilities, and those less comfortable with self-service technology, as well as store staff whose roles are affected by automation.
Nature of the problem situation (please describe at a high level the nature of the problem you will be focusing on i.e. when it occurred, what it concerns, who is affected)	Over the past several years, UK supermarkets have rapidly expanded self-checkout technology to reduce staffing costs and speed up service, particularly since the pandemic accelerated automation across retail. However, this shift has been accompanied by growing customer complaints about impersonal service, technical frustrations, and a rise in accidental and deliberate under-scanning ("self-checkout theft"), which some retailers have linked to increased shrinkage. The issue concerns how far to continue automating the customer journey without weakening trust, satisfaction, and loyalty, and affects customers, store staff, and retailers' bottom lines alike.
Stakeholders (please list the key stakeholders in the problem situation)	1. Store operations management; 2. Customer experience/service team; 3. Store-level cashiers and shop floor staff; 4. Security team; 5. IT/technology department; 6. Finance department; 7. HR department (staffing levels); 8. Senior/executive management; 9. Regular customers; 10. Elderly and disabled customers; 11. Trade unions representing retail staff; 12. Self-checkout technology suppliers; 13. Competitor supermarkets; 14. Local communities/high streets; 15. Consumer rights and retail industry bodies (e.g. British Retail Consortium).
Name the two stakeholders with conflict	Store Operations/Finance Management: focused on reducing labour costs and increasing checkout efficiency through expanding self-checkout technology. Customer Experience/Store Management: focused on protecting service quality, customer satisfaction, and the in-store shopping experience. Store Operations/Finance Management v Customer Experience/Store Management

Describe the conflict between the stakeholders	Operations and finance teams are incentivised to cut costs and improve checkout speed, and see self-checkout expansion as a clear efficiency win. Customer experience and store management teams see the same expansion as a key of declining satisfaction, more impersonal shopping trips, and rising shrinkage from under-scanning, and worry it damages long-term brand loyalty and footfall. Each side is optimising for a different metric (cost/efficiency vs. satisfaction/trust), and neither has clear evidence that fully resolves the trade-off.
Ambiguity (please explain why you think that this problem situation is ambiguous i.e. there is some confusion between cause and effect and the potential solutions)	It is unclear whether declining customer satisfaction and rising shrinkage are actually caused by self-checkout automation itself, or by other factors such as broader cost-of-living pressures, wider high-street decline, or reduced staff numbers generally. There is no single obvious solution: retailers could remove self-checkouts, redesign them, add more staff oversight, introduce hybrid models, or improve the technology itself, and it is not clear which (if any) would resolve both the cost and experience concerns simultaneously.

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PART 01

STAGE 1: Background and Context of Problem Situation

Background and Context

Over past 10 years, UK super shop (Tesco, Sainsbury, and Asda) has implemented the increased usage of self checkout (SCO) machines. The growing of SCO in operations accelerate by the contactless system implementation at COVD 19 pandemic, targeting mainly to cut down employee cost, store space optimization and assist rush hour customer service (Taylor, 2021). In 2024, the self service checkout transaction increases for more than 65% of total supermarket sells in the UK (BRC, 2024). However, such tremendous transformation results in an unexpected outcome that UK stores are unable to cope with 2 major problems. For retail loss, it rises and customer satisfactions decrease resulting from failures of POS (point of sale) terminal such as the persistent innocent items in bagging area, warnings and age checks delay (Beck, 2023). UK groceries shopping hit 1.1 billion at 2023-2024, caused mainly by voluntary under scan and substitute high value items with cheap ones at SCO stations (BRC, 2024). In response, retailers implement stern loss reduction strategies that include security barrier, required weight verification and overhead AI camera; while in place, these routines effectively deter theft, but may also build up dissatisfaction by creating tension at the store exit, discourage honest customer and impede checkout efficiency.

Identification of the Client

The proposed client for this project in the "consulting" process is the Executive Operations Committee represented by Director of Customer Experience & Brand Loyalty and Head of Store Operations & Logistics at UK prominent supershop chain. The higher management conflict involves such dual representatives: one prioritizes shopping experience, customer retention and brand loyalty; the other aims to tightly control costs, limit manpower and mitigate theft.

Complexity and Ambiguity

According to Checkland and Poulter (2006), the situation involves significant complexity and ambiguity.

Complexity: 15 groups of stakeholders involve, nonlinear feedback constantly emerges among customer shopping behavior, employee morality, store safety, technology reliability and operational efficiency.

Ambiguity: There is no widely-agreed ideal solution or root cause of issue, it is indeterminate whether declining customer satisfaction is mainly due to SCO system, external elements like cost of living increase and decline of high streets or poorly operated shop maintenance.

By assigning deactivation of weighing scales, the shop may experiencing decreases in customer satisfaction as well as plummeting in theft rate. While by prioritizing loss control at SCO station, such as stronger security gates, would negativize customer experience.

List of Stakeholders

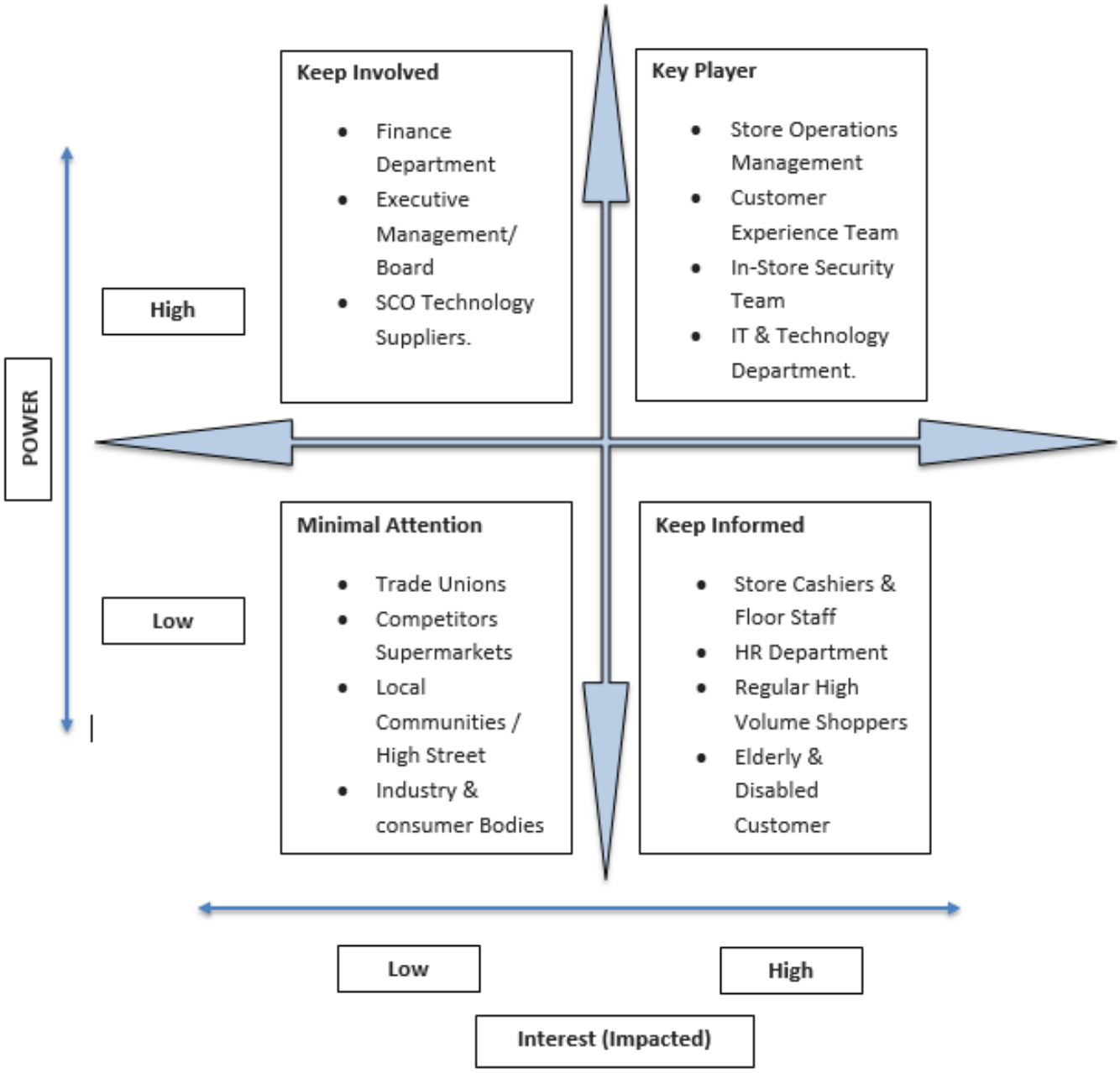
The table below outlines 15 main stakeholders within the UK supershops, detailing their relationships and main concern factor.

Stakeholder Name	Relationships (Good, Bad, Conflict)	What is on Their Mind? (Mindset & Concerns)
1. Store Operations Management	Conflict with (2), Good with (6)	Focus on reducing store hours spent on staff, increasing transaction speed and achieving quarterly KPI numbers
2. Customer Experience Team	Conflict with (1), Good with (9, 10)	Worry that impersonal checkout and high security cost damage customer loyalty and brings customers to rival shop
3. Store Cashiers & Floor Staff	Bad with (1), Conflict with (4)	Concern about losing job; verbally abused when system crash; overwhelmed by managing multiple SCO stations.
4. In Store Security Team	Conflict with (3, 9), Good with (6)	Annoyed by rising thefts, annoyed by untis to be scanned, torn between pursuing potential culprits and keeping customer friendly atmosphere
5. IT & Technology Department	Good with (1, 12), Bad with (3)	Dedicated to tech system's reliability and AI application and scanner hardware; angry about staffs' careless use of physical machines.
6. Finance Department	Good with (1), Conflict with (2)	Primarily focused on controlling labor cost and shrinkage reduction, capital investment.
7. HR Department	Conflict with (3, 11), Good with (1)	Facing high staff turnover, absenteeism, employee mental health and training in automated shop routine.
8. Executive Management	Good with (1, 6), Conflict with (14)	Striving to meet shareholder and investor expectations for profit growth, while maintaining the long term brand value and market share
9. Regular High Volume Shoppers	Good with (2), Conflict with (4)	Expect efficient and frictionless checkouts, frustrated with false alarm signals and delays
10. Elderly & Disabled Customers	Good with (2), Bad with (1)	Feeling ignored or excluded by complicated kiosk touchscreen, long hang time in queue, disappearing no-help checkout Despondency.
11. Trade Unions (e.g., Usdaw)	Conflict with (1, 6, 8), Good with (3)	Supporting worker rights, opposing forced redundancies, and demanding safer working environments.
12. SCO Hardware/AI Suppliers	Good with (1, 5), Conflict with (6)	Looking to sell new tech and maintenance contracts; blaming store systems for technical issues.

13. Competitor Supermarkets	Conflict with (8), Bad with (1)	Observing industry trends; some, like Booths, are gaining ground by removing SCOs, while others push for more frictionless checkout options.
14. Local High Street Communities	Conflict with (8), Good with (10)	Concerned about the loss of human interaction in town centers, community breakdown, and increased antisocial behavior near unstaffed stores.
15. Industry & Consumer Bodies (BRC)	Good with (8, 9), Neutral with (1)	Requesting police action against retail crime and pushing for fair and accessible customer service across the UK.

Power Interest Matrix

Based on stakeholder influence and interest on the outcome of checkout plan, following SSM (Checkland & Poulter, 2006), actors are categorized: Key players: influence and interested.



Internal actors who can make decisions to the whole system and need to know about the outcome of success Keep satisfied: influence but not interested. Shop owners, external to organization, manage to impact decision; interested in the shop future External: interested but not influence. Customers, communities; want better customer service but powerless Changing between categories is dynamic as actors' personal values shift and system environment changes.

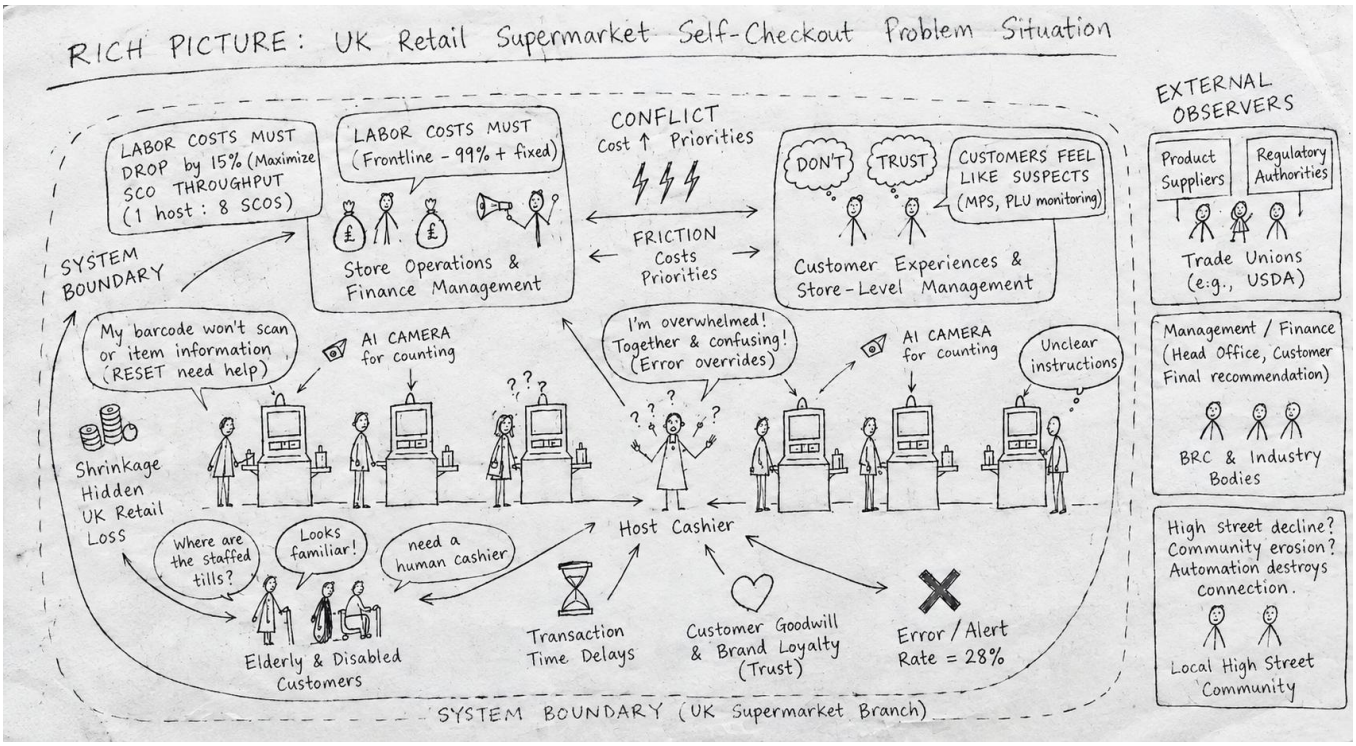
STAGE 2: The Problem Situation Expressed Rich Picture

Introduction and Evidence of Research

Rich Pictures (RP) is a visualization technique used in SSM, no boundaries setting and tells detail of complex situation (Checkland & Poulter, 2006). Research literature indicate that human error at SCO system, e.g., forgot to scan retail items in shopping cart bottom, accounts for approximately 40% of shop shrinkage, while substantial theft is responsible for the rest 60% (Beck, 2023). Meanwhile, customer dissatisfaction with store self service points increases by 28% compared with previous year in UK (BRC, 2024).

Rich Picture Architectural Description

The following diagram illustrated a typical operational context at UK supermarket store depicting relationships, conflicts and external factors.



Structural Components and Key Characteristics

The Rich Picture includes five essential elements of the Soft Systems Methodology (SSM) that are required by the assessment criteria (Checkland & Poulter, 2006):

Identified Stakeholders: All 15 internal and external individuals are included, each representing a specific role in the operations.

System Boundary: This is clearly defined to include the areas of store operations, checkout areas, security measures, and management functions.

Relationships and Value Exchange: There is strong agreement between Finance and Operations, but there are major disagreements between Security and Customer Experience.

Key Issues and Concerns: These are expressed through the perspectives of the stakeholders, such as security concerns about theft versus cashiers feeling overwhelmed by red light overrides.

External Observers: These actors, such as Unions, the British Retail Consortium (BRC), and community groups, are positioned outside the system and exert influence through regulation, social, and political pressures.

PART 02

STAGE 3: Purpose Statements, CATWOE and Root Definitions

Stakeholder Selection and Conflict Justification

To conduct a full SSM analysis I selected two major stakeholders engaged in a zero sum conflict:

1. Store Operations and Finance Management (SOFM)

Power/Interest: High Power / High Interest

Key Player Perspective: The checkout area is optimized as an operational processing area that minimizes labor cost per transaction by exploiting maximum technology.

2. Customer Experience and Store Level Management (CESM)

Power/Interest: High Power / High Interest

Key Player Perspective: The checkout area is an essential final customer touch point from which trusting brand equity, accessibility, and service goodwill must be protected.

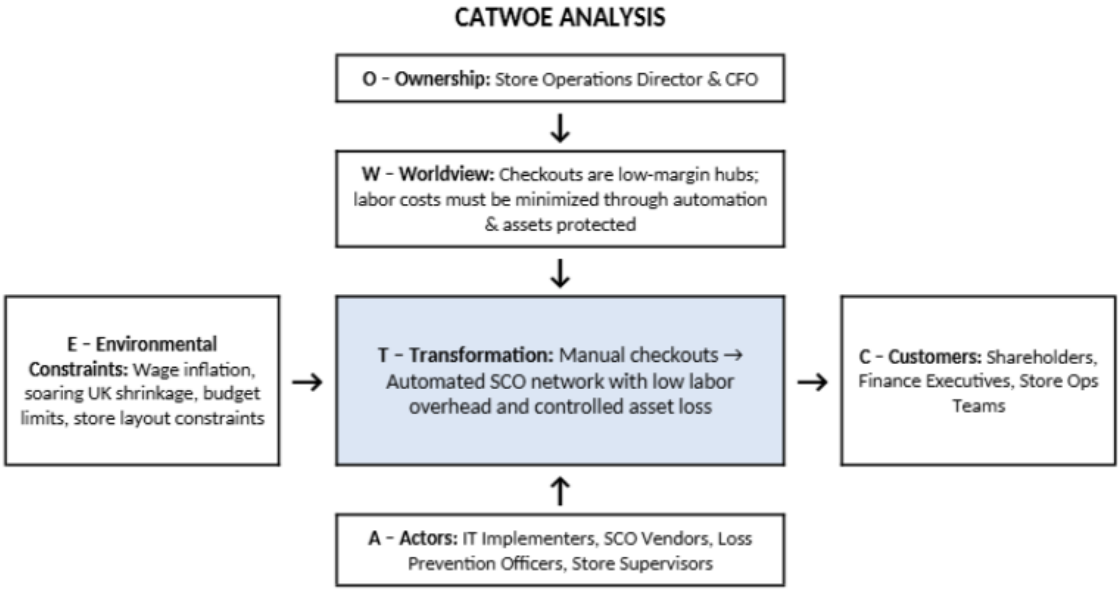
Dispute: For SOFM the goal is to decrease labor and shrinkage by controlling security via automated security systems.

Friction is a worthwhile operational tradeoff. For CESM, these tools like overhead AI cameras, weight scale locks and scan gates, are friction generating mechanisms that annoy customers, alienate shoppers, promote staff abuse, and reduce sales.

Stakeholder 1: Store Operations and Finance Management Analysis

Component	Description
P (What)	**Optimize in store transaction throughput, and control labor costs.**
Q (How)	**Maximizing self checkout terminal use, and integrating automated loss prevention surveillance equipment**
R (Why)	**Achieve corporate profit margin targets and protect retail assets.**
Full PQR Statement	**A system to optimize in store transaction throughput and control labor costs (P) by maximizing self checkout terminal use and integrating automated loss prevention surveillance equipment (Q) in order to achieve corporate profit margin targets and protect retail assets (R).**

CATWOE Analysis



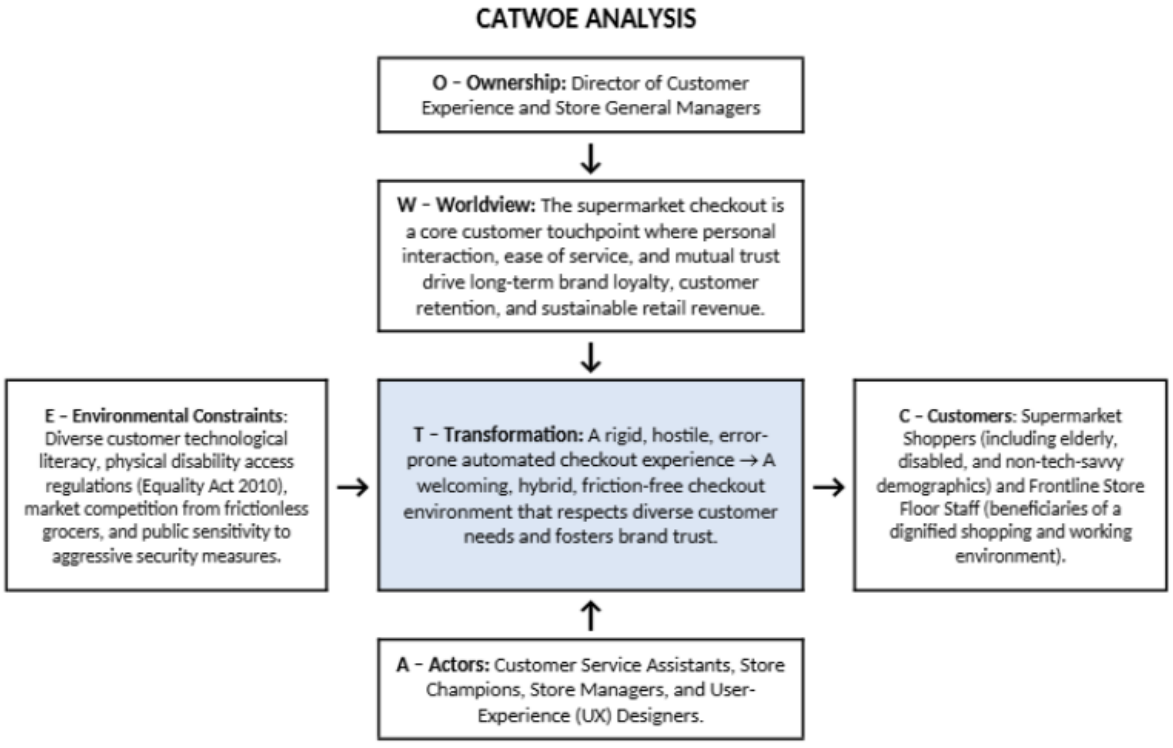
Root Definition:

This Root Definition describes a Store Operations and Finance Management system aimed at replacing expensive manual checkouts with an automated, low labor self service network in a context of wage inflation and retail theft. It is premised on the concept that profits are closely linked to asset protection and cost containment, deploying high density SCOs, AI surveillance, and sensor based exit gates to reduce costs, speed transactions, and maximize shareholder value

Stakeholder 2: Customer Experience and Store Level Management Analysis

Component	Description
P (What)	**Deliver an accessible, dignified, and smooth checkout environment.**
Q (How)	**Balancing hybrid human assisted and automated checkout lanes with empowered, customer focused store staff**
R (Why)	**Improve customer satisfaction, maintain brand trust, and build long term customer loyalty**
Full PQR Statement	**A system to deliver an accessible, dignified, and smooth checkout environment (P) by balancing hybrid human assisted and automated checkout lanes with empowered, customer focused store staff (Q) in order to improve customer satisfaction, maintain brand trust, and build long term customer loyalty (R)**

CATWOE Analysis



Root Definition:

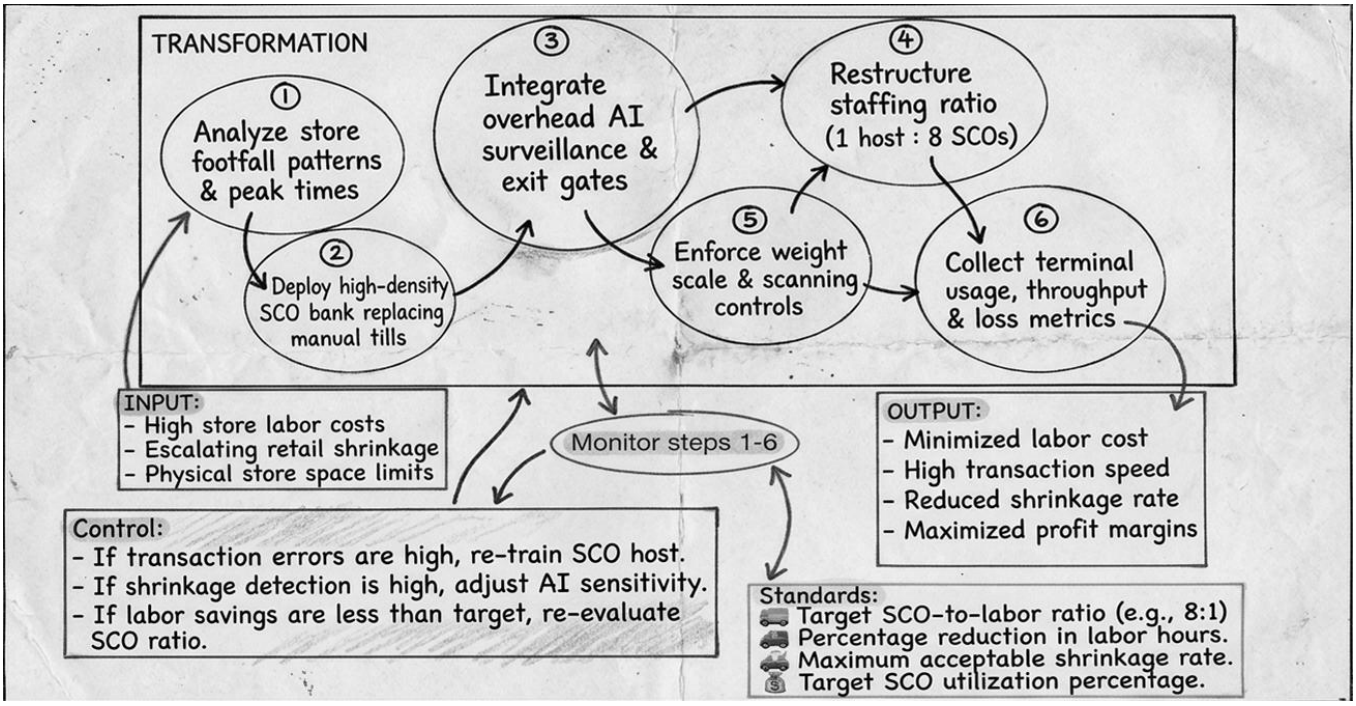
This is a customer experience grounded system, operating to statutory accessiblity standards and in a competitive retail environment, to transform an inhospitable automated checkout space into a customer driven, customer welcoming, customer responsive system.

It is based on the proposition that customer trust and satisfaction lead to long term business success, by deploying easy to use self service terminals, personal shopping assistants, and dedicated concierge staff to ensure pleasurable interactions for all age, income, and ability categories.

STAGE 4: Conceptual Models and Systems Analysis

Conceptual Model 1: Store Operations and Finance Management Perspective

The conceptual model illustrates the operational activities needed to implement the transformation described in Root Definition 1.

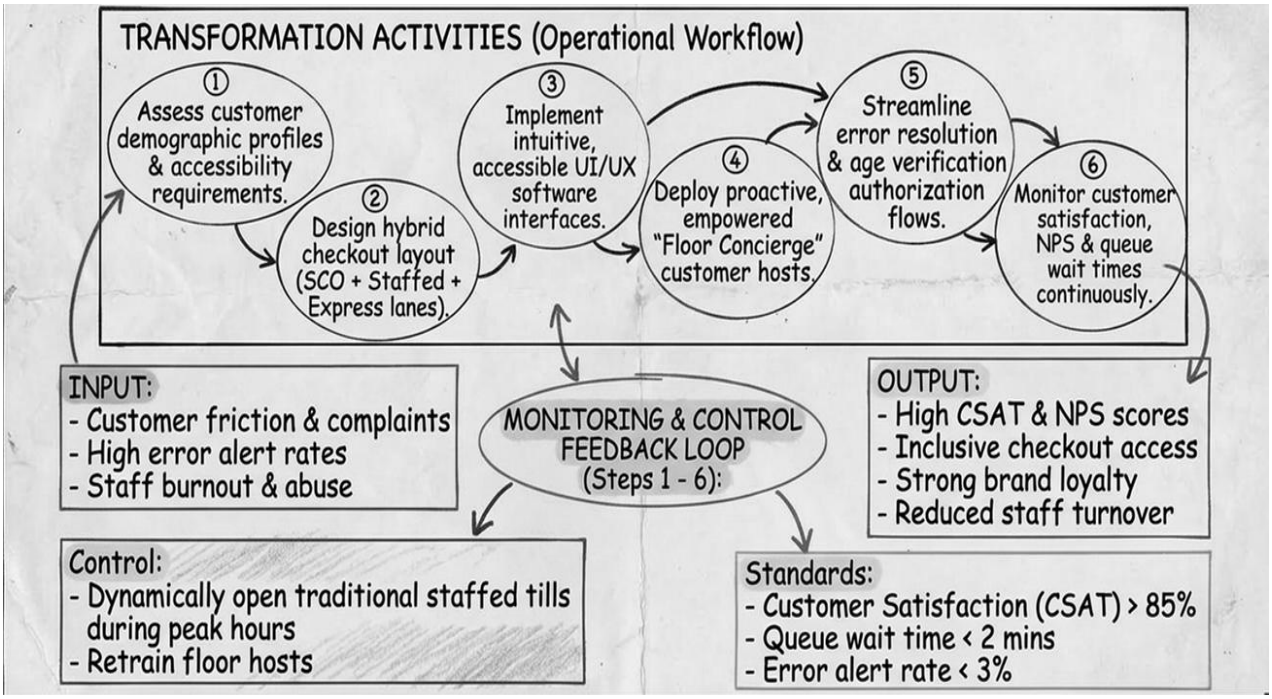


Three E s Analysis for Conceptual Model 1

Criteria	Specific Measurement Indicator	Performance Standard / Target
Efficacy	Percentage of store transactions successfully processed through automated SCO terminals without human intervention.	Target: >= 80% non-assisted completion rate.
Efficiency	Total store labor cost per 1,000 completed customer transactions.	Target: Reduction from £120/1,000 transactions (manual baseline) to <= £45/1,000 transactions.
Effectiveness	Overall store operating margin expansion and total annual reduction in stock shrinkage value (£).	Target: Net margin increase of 1.5% and shrinkage maintained below 0.75% of total sales.

Conceptual Model 2: Customer Experience and Store Management Perspective

Conceptual Model 2 outlines the meaningful activities required to achieve the customer centric vision detailed in Root Definition 2.



Three E s Analysis for Conceptual Model 2

Criteria	Specific Measurement Indicator	Performance Standard / Target
Efficacy	Customer Satisfaction (CSAT) score and Net Promoter Score (NPS) measured at exit kiosks.	Target: CSAT >= 85% positive rating; NPS >= +40.
Efficiency	Average customer transaction time (seconds) and average queue wait time per customer.	Target: Total checkout duration <= 120s; queue wait time <= 90s.
Effectiveness	Repeat customer footfall retention rate and percentage reduction in reported customer friction incidents.	Target: 92% customer retention rate; 50% reduction in formal complaints.

PART 03

STAGE 5: Critical Reflection on SSM Application

Gibbs' Reflective Cycle Framework

To critically assess my learning and analytical process during this consultancy project, I have structured my reflection using Gibbs' Reflective Cycle (1988).

1. Description: How do I see my SSM analytical experience in this consultancy module?

2. Feelings: How did I initially experience and feel about soft complexity in this professional situation?

3. Evaluation: What worked well and what technical barriers did I observe?

4. Analysis: What meanings can I derive from understanding the international stakeholder perspectives?

5. Conclusion: What larger lessons can I draw about the practice of soft management consulting?

6. Action Plan: How should I approach soft challenge on future systems projects?

Critical Evaluation of SSM Learning

1. Description: I used the Soft Systems Methodology (SSM) in the module to tackle a real world business problem: balancing self checkout automation, customer experience and theft control in UK retail. I developed Rich Pictures, formulated CATWOE Parameters, developed Root Definitions, constructed Conceptual Models for conflicting parties, compared ideal models to real world observations, and created a plan for implementation.

2. Feeling: I felt at first a little overwhelmed by the ambiguity of the problem. Coming from a linear, hard systems background, I was looking for a single technical solution, such as the best AI camera software.I was irritated by the idea that different stakeholders had seemingly incompatible goals for the checkout area. However, during the workshop sessions I gradually became interested that SSM offered a way to manage this complexity.

3 Analysis: Using SSM to chart 15 stakeholders helped me avoid premature convergence on a solution. Working through the structuring of CATWOE Elements helped me take the views of diverse actors seriously by acknowledging that the CFO's Financial logic and a grandma's shopping logic are equally valid reasons for how a system can operate. 4. What Was Difficult: Successfully combining two different root definition formats-concise subject-action-object and the longer, challenge-correction-formulation style-was difficult.

Evolution of Problem Understanding Across Iterations

Iteration 1 (Perception): This was a technical failure-self checkout machines break down regularly, and shoplifters abuse unmanned tills.

Iteration 2 (Rich picture): This was an organizational problem-Store Operations forces reduction of labour, resulting in stressed-out staff and Security putting in hostile exit gates.

Iteration 3 (Conceptual modelling and the 3 Es): This was a systemic, philosophical problem-hard to get agreement-trade-offs between the Operations side (cost paradigm) and Customer Experience (trust paradigm) are incompatible-solution: accommodating them; look for something both paradigms can change.

Strengths and Limitations of SSM

Unpack Ambiguity: SSM is suitable for unstructured settings, and prevents consultants from offering technically hard solutions to soft human and cultural problems.

Hidden assumptions: By making Worldview explicit, SSM exposes that loss prevention controls tend to break down because "All customers are potential thieves" impacts on good will.

Limitations of SSM

Insufficient Quantitative Methods: SSM does not include the financial modeling tools or layout mechanics necessary to generate precise dollar-and-cent budget figures.

Implementation Deficit: SSM describes 'feasible and desirable change' but does not specify how to manage the project, deal with resistance, or implement technical solutions.

Insights from Seminar Group

Peer Challenge on Rich Pictures: Peers explained how visual metaphors (drawing security cameras as panopticon eyes) conveyed the nuances of the operation better than words.

Debate of CATWOE Boundaries: whether cashiers in the store should be actors or customers helped me understand perspective dependent modeling.

Influence of Reflection on Client Recommendations

This thinking of my reflection shaped my recommendations. The recommendation was not to just remove all self checkouts and replace them with fully AI based surveillance but to look at it through the lens of Checkland's meaning of Accommodation (Checkland & Poulter, 2006). Recommendations are around hybrid operation models that meet thecost needs of Finance and uphold Customer Experience through dignified customer journey design.

PART 04

STAGE 6: Recommendations and Evaluation

Comparison of Conceptual Models with Real World Reality

To generate actionable recommendations, the idealized activities from Conceptual Models 1 and 2 are compared directly with the current operational reality observed in UK supermarkets.

Table 1: Comparison Matrix for Conceptual Model 1 (Store Operations & Finance Perspective)

Activity No.	Ideal System Activity (Model 1)	Real-World Reality in Stores	Proposed Change
1	Analyze store footfall and transaction volume patterns dynamically.	Static scheduling based on historical weekly averages; unable to adjust to sudden queue spikes.	Implement dynamic, AI-driven labor scheduling linked to real-time footfall sensors.
2	Deploy high-density SCO banks replacing manual tills.	Stores have over-indexed on SCOs, removing almost all staffed tills in urban locations.	Maintain high-density SCOs but reserve mandatory staffed 'Express' lanes.
3	Integrate overhead AI surveillance and exit gates seamlessly.	AI cameras generate high false-positives; exit gates cause bottlenecks and customer anger.	Recalibrate AI sensitivity thresholds and replace rigid exit gates with soft-verification prompts.
4	Restructure cashier staffing ratio to 1 host per 8 SCO terminals.	Cashiers are assigned 10–12 terminals, leading to severe red-light override delays.	Cap host ratio at 1:6 for standard SCOs and 1:4 for trolley SCO zones.
5	Enforce automated weight scale security controls.	Weight scales glitch frequently on light items (e.g., greeting cards), freezing terminals.	Disable weight scales for low-risk items; rely on visual AI item recognition.

Table 2: Comparison Matrix for Conceptual Model 2 (Customer Experience Perspective)

Activity No.	Ideal System Activity (Model 1)	Real-World Reality in Stores	Proposed Change
1	Assess customer demographic profiles and accessibility needs.	One-size-fits-all checkout layout applied across all store formats regardless of local demographics.	Tailor checkout lane configurations based on local store demographic data.
2	Design hybrid layout with SCO, Staffed, and Assisted lanes.	Staffed lanes are frequently closed or unstaffed, forcing all shoppers into SCO banks.	Guarantee at least two traditional staffed lanes open during all operational hours.
3	Implement intuitive, accessible UI/UX software interfaces.	UI is cluttered with promotional pop-ups, slow button responses, and confusing menus.	Redesign SCO terminal UI with high-contrast text, simplified menus, and 1-click payment options.
4	Deploy proactive, empowered 'Floor Concierge' hosts.	Staff are trained as 'watchdogs' focusing on theft prevention rather than service assistance.	Re-train hosts as customer service concierges equipped with handheld override tablets.
5	Streamline error resolution and age verification flows.	Age verification requires host to physically walk over and scan a physical badge.	Implement remote age approval via host handheld smartwatches/tablets.

Scope for Improvement: Accommodation vs. Consensus

The analysis indicates that accommodation (Checkland & Poulter, 2006) is the only feasible way of handling these core beliefs since Store Operations/Finance and Customer Experience have opposing beliefs, namely saving money and improving service. Accommodation in this case entails allowing all parties to achieve their high-level goals without losing anything of value: the Operations group can accommodate by assigning a few more cashier stations for the same total number of staff, and Customer Experience can accommodate by accepting the use of non-intrusive loss prevention technologies.

Evaluation of Feasible and Desirable Changes

CHANGE 1: Hybrids 'Smart Assist' Check Out Zone Architecture Make 3 zones at the store exit: (a) High Speed Self Bagless Rapid Check Out, (b) Trolley Integrated Self Bagless Check Out, (b) Assisted & Social Lanes.

Feasibility: High (only small layout adjustment needed)

Desirability: High (more options, no queues, dignity for seniors)

CHANGE 2: Mobile Tablet Concierge & Remote Age Validation Equip SCO hosts with tablets or wrist worn tablets to validate age restricted products, correct errors and assist shoppers from over 10 meters

Feasibility: High (use existing Wi Fi and third party software)

Desirability: High (reduce the time cars sit at red lights, dignify staff)

CHANGE 3: Soft AI Loss Prevention with Soft Verification Conversations Suspend the hard check scales and swipe gates, replace with overhead AI vision cameras that spots non scanned items and direct shoppers to friendly screen based 'did you forget to scan this item?' messages

Feasibility: Medium (requires software upgrades and AI nuance)

Desirability: High (reduces loss, avoids police type confrontation)

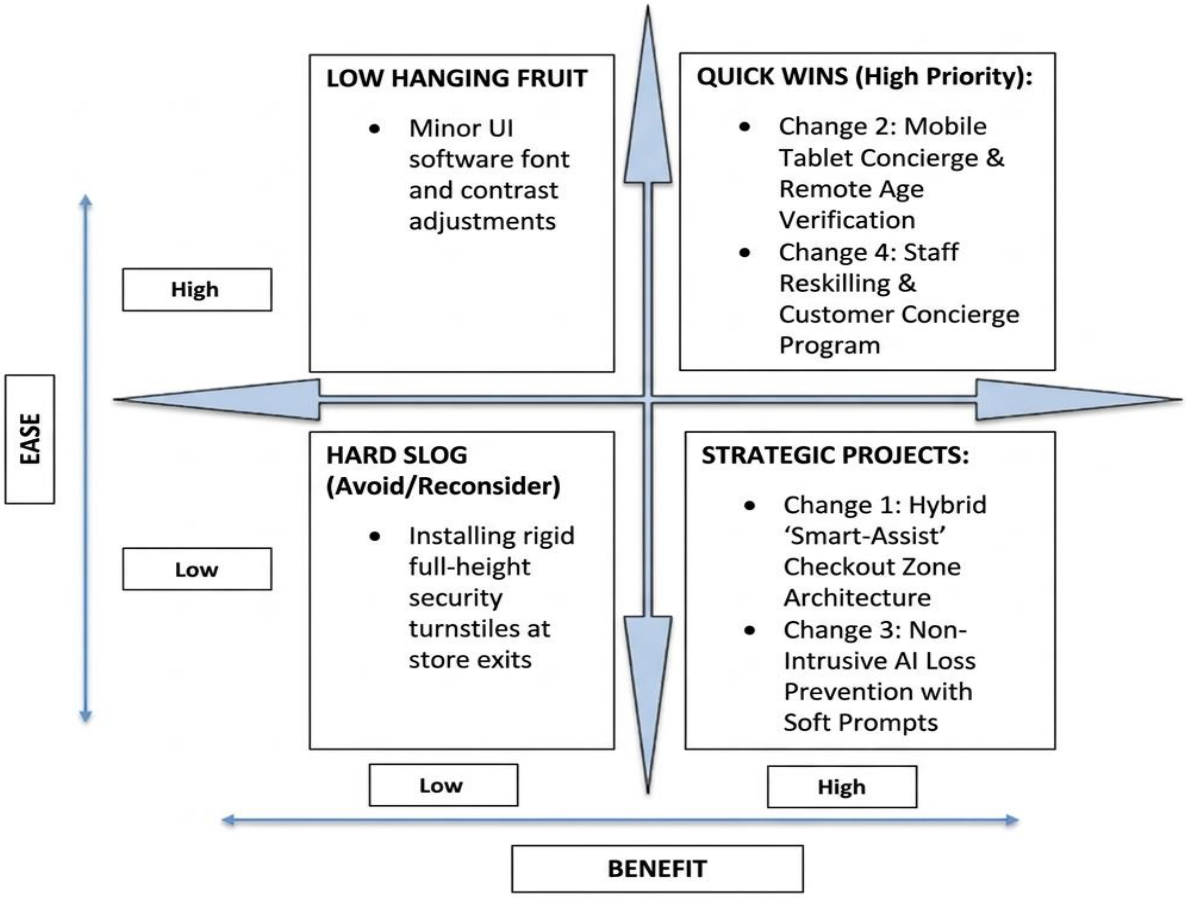
CHANGE 4: Staff Reskilling & Customer Concierge Culture Program Position frontline staff as confident 'Customer Hosts' that know how to calm, support and resolve tech issues, check shoppers out and assist with technology use

Feasibility: High (aligned to HR budgets and union agreements)

Desirability: High (improves staff morale and reduces turnover, improves shopping experience)

Ease Benefit Matrix

The four proposed changes are assessed using an Ease Benefit Matrix to help the client decide on the order of implementation.



Strategic Action Implementation Plan

A phased rollout allows for quick wins as well as longer term system changes.

PHASE 1: QUICK WINS (0-6 months)

M1: Deploy tablets on the SCO floor at the top 50 flagship stores.

M2: Calibrate the SCO weight scales so they disable for items under 200g in order to prevent false error locks.

M3: Issue a directive for always ensuring two traditional staffed tills are open.

M4: Train front line staff in conflict de escalation using Store Union representatives.

PHASE 2: MEDIUM TERM (6-18 months)

M7: Roll out the environmental design changes to implement the three zone hybrid checkout system at the high volume hypermarkets.

M9: Deploy soft prompt AI overhead camera software replacing gate locks at trial stores.

M12: Initial evaluation of customer satisfaction, shrinkage and transaction time measurements.

M15: Calibrate AI sensitivity levels against loss prevention monitors and customer feedback.

PHASE 3: LONG TERM (18+ months)

M18: Complete nationwide rollout of the Hybrid 'Smart Assist' Checkout Architecture for all store formats.

M21: Fully integrate AI based labor scheduling to put in 'digital fences' requiring Store Management to update staffing levels based on real time store footfall.

M24: Make regular SSM (Store System Management) reviews part of quarterly Executive Operations Committee meetings.

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